

ESSENTIAL PROTECTION GUIDE

Fake Developers, False Promises & Forged Documents

The Nigerian Real Estate Survival Guide

Written by

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Foreword: The Crisis No One Talks About

As Chief Operating Officer of 12th City Real Estate Developers, I have spent the last decade building systems to protect our clients and deliver on our promises. But I have also witnessed a darker side of this industry—one that claims billions of naira from unsuspecting Nigerians every year.

The statistics are staggering. Industry estimates suggest that as many as 40% of real estate projects in Nigeria are either abandoned or involve some form of fraud. The Nigerian real estate sector loses an estimated N500 billion annually to fake developers, land grabbers, and document forgers.

40%

PROJECTS
ABANDONED

N500B

ANNUAL LOSSES

65%

BUYER COMPLAINTS

5-7 Yrs

AVG RECOVERY TIME

Every week, I receive calls from distraught Nigerians who have lost their life savings to smooth-talking fraudsters. Teachers who saved for twenty years. Business owners who invested their profits. Young professionals who took loans to buy their first homes. All of them victims of a system that preys on hope and trust.

"The most dangerous criminals in Nigerian real estate don't break into homes—they break into dreams. They don't steal with guns; they steal with pens, forged documents, and false promises."

This book is not just a guide—it is a survival manual. I am going to show you exactly how these criminals operate, the specific documents they forge, the lies they tell, and most importantly, how you can protect yourself and your family from becoming their next victim.

The tools in this book are the same ones we use at 12th City to verify every project, every document, and every transaction. They are the result of years of experience, countless investigations, and a commitment to integrity in an industry that desperately needs it.

Read this book carefully. Apply its lessons diligently. Share it with everyone you know who is considering a real estate investment. Together, we can make the Nigerian real estate market safer for everyone.

Dr. Fadokun Oluwole

Chief Operating Officer

12th City Real Estate Developers LTD

Chapter 1: The Anatomy of a Real Estate Scam

1.1 How Fake Developers Operate

Fake developers in Nigeria have refined their operations into a sophisticated system of deception. Understanding how they work is the first step to protecting yourself.

The Typical Scam Lifecycle

Phase 1: Setup (Months 1-3)

- Register a company name that sounds legitimate
- Create professional-looking websites and social media
- Rent a temporary office in a prestigious location
- Print business cards and marketing materials
- Hire salespeople on commission

Phase 2: The Bait (Months 3-6)

- Identify land in an area with development potential
- Create fake or doctored land documents
- Launch aggressive marketing campaigns
- Offer prices 30-50% below market
- Create urgency: "Limited units available"

Phase 3: The Catch (Months 6-12)

- Collect deposits from multiple buyers
- May start minimal construction to maintain appearance
- Continue selling to new victims

- Delay tactics when buyers ask questions

Phase 4: The Disappearance (Months 12-18)

- Office suddenly closed
- Phone numbers disconnected
- Website taken down
- Money gone, no trace of the perpetrators

The "Omonile" Connection

Many fake developers collaborate with local land grabbers (omoniles) who provide access to disputed land. The developer sells the land, the omonile provides "security," and both disappear when the real owners show up.

1.2 The Psychology of Deception

Fake developers are master manipulators who exploit common psychological triggers:

Greed: They offer prices too good to be true. A plot in Lekki for N5 million when the market price is N15 million? Many buyers suspend their judgment when they see a "deal."

Urgency: "Only 3 plots left!" "Price goes up tomorrow!" "Someone else is interested!" These pressure tactics bypass rational thinking.

Social Proof: They show you photos of other "buyers" (often staged), testimonials (often fake), and construction progress (often from different projects).

Authority: They claim connections with government officials, traditional rulers, or celebrities. They display fake awards and certifications.

Trust Building: They invest time in building a relationship, remembering personal details, and appearing genuinely concerned about your welfare.

1.3 Real Stories, Real Losses

Case Study: The Ibeju-Lekki Disaster

In 2019, a developer sold 200 plots in Ibeju-Lekki for N3 million each—half the market price. They showed buyers a beautiful estate plan, provided "C of O" documents, and even started some foundation work.

By 2020, the office was empty. The documents were forged. The land belonged to the government. 200 families lost a combined N600 million. The developer had fled to Dubai.

Lesson: Below-market prices are a red flag, not an opportunity.

Case Study: The Abuja Duplex Scam

A Lagos-based developer sold duplexes in Abuja's Maitama district for N80 million each—market price was N150 million. They collected 70% deposits from 50 buyers (N2.8 billion total).

The land was real, but the developer never had the right to sell it. The actual owner discovered the fraud when construction began. Buyers are still in court five years later.

Lesson: Always verify the seller's legal right to the property.

Chapter 2: The 10 Questions That Expose Fraudsters

Before you hand over a single naira, ask these ten questions. A legitimate developer will have clear, verifiable answers. A fraudster will evade, deflect, or become defensive.

Question 1: What is your company's CAC registration number?

Why it matters: Every legitimate business in Nigeria must be registered with the Corporate Affairs Commission.

Red flag: They give excuses, provide a number that doesn't exist, or claim to be "in the process" of registration.

Verification: Visit cac.gov.ng and search the company name. The registration should be active for at least 2-3 years.

Question 2: Can I see the original land title documents?

Why it matters: The original documents prove legal ownership. Copies can be forged.

Red flag: They only have copies, claim originals are "with the lawyer," or refuse physical inspection.

Verification: Insist on seeing originals. Take photos and verify with the issuing authority.

Question 3: Has this land ever been sold to anyone else?

Why it matters: Some fraudsters sell the same land to multiple buyers.

Red flag: They get defensive, claim it's a "stupid question," or refuse to provide a search report.

Verification: Conduct a land search at the state land registry. Cost: N5,000-N20,000. Worth every kobo.

Question 4: Can I visit the land with my own surveyor?

Why it matters: An independent surveyor can verify boundaries, check for encumbrances, and confirm the land matches the documents.

Red flag: They insist on using "their" surveyor, claim the land is "not accessible," or demand payment before the visit.

Verification: Hire a registered surveyor (check with the Surveyors Council of Nigeria). Cost: N50,000-N150,000.

Question 5: What is your track record? Can I see completed projects?

Why it matters: Legitimate developers have a history of delivered projects.

Red flag: They claim this is their "first project," show you projects that don't exist, or provide only renderings.

Verification: Visit claimed completed projects. Talk to actual residents, not just the developer's references.

Question 6: Why is your price significantly lower than the market rate?

Why it matters: Real estate follows market principles. If it's too cheap, something is wrong.

Red flag: They claim "special government allocation," "family land," or "promotional pricing."

Verification: Research market prices in the area. If their price is more than 15% below market, investigate thoroughly.

Question 7: Can I pay through a bank transfer to your company account?

Why it matters: Cash payments leave no trail. Personal accounts obscure the transaction.

Red flag: They demand cash, ask for payment to a personal account, or suggest payment to a third party.

Verification: The account name must match the company name exactly. Verify the account with the bank if unsure.

Question 8: What happens if the project is delayed or abandoned?

Why it matters: Legitimate developers have contingency plans and refund policies.

Red flag: They promise "it will never happen," refuse to discuss it, or have no written policy.

Verification: The sales agreement should clearly state refund terms, timelines, and penalties for non-delivery.

Question 9: Can I have my lawyer review the agreement?

Why it matters: A lawyer can spot unfair clauses, hidden risks, and fraudulent terms.

Red flag: They pressure you to sign immediately, claim "this is our standard agreement," or offer a "discount" for quick signing.

Verification: Never sign without legal review. A good property lawyer costs N50,000-N200,000. It's insurance, not an expense.

Question 10: Can I get references from previous buyers?

Why it matters: Past buyers can tell you the truth about their experience.

Red flag: They provide only phone numbers (which turn out to be their employees), or refuse to provide references.

Verification: Ask for 5-10 references. Call them independently. Visit them if possible. Ask specific questions about delivery timeline, document authenticity, and any issues.

Chapter 3: Document Verification Checklist

Documents are the foundation of property ownership. Fake developers excel at creating convincing forgeries. This chapter teaches you how to verify the four most critical documents.

3.1 Certificate of Occupancy (C of O)

The C of O is the highest form of land title in Nigeria. It is issued by the state government and grants the holder statutory right of occupancy for 99 years.

What to Look For:

- ✓ Original certificate with security features (watermark, hologram, serial number)
- ✓ Correct land size and location
- ✓ Valid date of issuance
- ✓ Governor's signature and state seal
- ✓ Survey plan number that matches the physical survey

Red Flags:

- ✗ Photocopies presented as originals
- ✗ Mismatched survey numbers
- ✗ Recent C of O for land that has been "owned" for years
- ✗ Typos, grammatical errors, or poor print quality
- ✗ Missing security features

Where to Verify:

Visit the State Lands Bureau or Ministry of Lands. Bring the C of O number and survey plan. Verification costs N5,000-N20,000 and takes 1-5 working days.

3.2 Deed of Assignment

A Deed of Assignment transfers ownership from one party to another. It must be registered to be legally binding.

What to Look For:

- ✓ Clear identification of assignor (seller) and assignee (buyer)
- ✓ Accurate property description matching survey plan
- ✓ Consideration (price) clearly stated
- ✓ Signatures of both parties and witnesses
- ✓ Registration stamp and number from the land registry

Red Flags:

- ✗ Unregistered deed (not stamped at the registry)
- ✗ Vague property description
- ✗ Missing signatures or witnesses
- ✗ Deed dated before the assignor's own ownership

3.3 Survey Plan

A survey plan shows the exact boundaries and measurements of the land. It is prepared by a registered surveyor.

What to Look For:

- ✓ Surveyor's seal and registration number
- ✓ Beacon numbers matching physical beacons on the land
- ✓ Coordinates that can be verified
- ✓ Date of survey
- ✓ Approval stamp from the Surveyor General's office

Red Flags:

- ✗ No surveyor's seal or registration number
- ✗ Beacons that don't exist on the ground
- ✗ Coordinates that place the land in a different location
- ✗ Survey date that doesn't match other documents

Physical Verification:

Visit the land with a registered surveyor. They will locate the beacons, verify measurements, and confirm the land matches the survey plan. This is the most important verification step.

3.4 Building Plan Approval

For properties with existing or planned structures, building plan approval from the relevant planning authority is mandatory.

What to Look For:

- ✓ Approval letter from the planning authority
- ✓ Approved building plans matching the actual structure
- ✓ Development permit number
- ✓ Payment receipts for approval fees

Red Flags:

- ✗ Building constructed without approval
- ✗ Structure different from approved plans
- ✗ Approval from wrong authority
- ✗ Fake approval letters (verify with the planning authority)

The "Excision in Process" Lie

Many fraudsters claim the land is under "excision" (process of releasing government land to communities). They show fake excision letters or claim it's "almost approved."

Truth: Until excision is gazetted (published in the official government gazette), the land belongs to the government. Anyone selling it is committing fraud.

Verification: Demand to see the gazette. Verify it at the State Lands Bureau.

Chapter 4: Developer Background Check Template

Before investing with any developer, conduct this comprehensive background check. Use this as your checklist:

Step 1: Company Registration Verification

Check	How to Verify	Pass/Fail
CAC Registration	Search cac.gov.ng	_____
Active Status	Check if company is active, not dissolved	_____
Registration Age	Minimum 2 years recommended	_____
Directors' Names	Match with people you meet	_____
Annual Returns	Check if filed up to date	_____

Step 2: Physical Office Verification

Check	How to Verify	Pass/Fail
Office Exists	Visit the address	_____
Permanent Location	Not a shared/virtual office	_____
Staff Present	Multiple employees, not just salespeople	_____
Professional Setup	Proper signage, equipment, organization	_____
Operating Hours	Consistent, reliable opening times	_____

Step 3: Track Record Verification

Check	How to Verify	Pass/Fail
Completed Projects	Visit sites, talk to residents	_____
Ongoing Projects	Check construction progress	_____
Project Timeline	Verify delivery dates claimed	_____
Customer References	Call 5+ past buyers independently	_____
Online Reviews	Search Google, social media, forums	_____

Step 4: Professional Affiliations

Check	How to Verify	Pass/Fail
Real Estate Developers Association	Check REDAN membership	_____
Chamber of Commerce	Verify with local chamber	_____
Industry Awards	Verify authenticity of claimed awards	_____
Professional Certifications	Check with issuing bodies	_____

The 48-Hour Rule

Never make a payment within 48 hours of first contact with a developer, no matter how good the "deal" seems. Use this time to complete your background check. Legitimate developers will respect your due diligence. Fraudsters will pressure you to decide quickly.

Chapter 5: Warning Signs & Red Flags

After years of investigating real estate fraud, I have identified the most common warning signs. If you encounter any of these, proceed with extreme caution—or walk away entirely.

Critical Red Flags (Deal Breakers)

- ✗ **Price 30%+ below market:** If it seems too good to be true, it is.
- ✗ **Cash-only payments:** Legitimate businesses accept bank transfers.
- ✗ **Pressure to decide immediately:** "Today only" deals are scams.
- ✗ **Refusal to provide documents:** No documents, no deal.
- ✗ **Personal account payments:** Always pay to the company account.
- ✗ **No physical office:** Or an office that looks temporary.
- ✗ **Unregistered company:** Check CAC before anything else.
- ✗ **No track record:** First project with no experienced team.
- ✗ **Reluctance to allow inspection:** They control when and how you see the land.
- ✗ **Excuses for everything:** Fraudsters are professional excuse-makers.

Behavioral Red Flags

- ✗ **Too friendly too fast:** Building false trust to lower your guard.
- ✗ **Name-dropping:** Constant mentions of powerful connections.
- ✗ **Religious manipulation:** Using faith to bypass your skepticism.
- ✗ **Emotional appeals:** "Don't you trust me?" is a manipulation tactic.
- ✗ **Defensive when questioned:** Legitimate developers welcome scrutiny.
- ✗ **Vague answers:** Evasive responses to specific questions.
- ✗ **Changing stories:** Details that don't match across conversations.

- ✗ **Unavailable for meetings:** Always "traveling" or "in a meeting."

Document Red Flags

- ✗ **Photocopies only:** Never accept copies as proof of ownership.
- ✗ **Recent documents for old land:** New C of O for land "owned" for years.
- ✗ **Mismatched information:** Names, sizes, or locations don't align.
- ✗ **No registration stamps:** Unregistered documents are worthless.
- ✗ **Poor quality printing:** Government documents have security features.
- ✗ **Missing pages:** Incomplete document sets.
- ✗ **Wrong signatures:** Signatures that don't match known officials.

The "Trusted Friend" Trap

Many victims are introduced to fake developers by friends, family, or colleagues who have already invested (or claim to have). The trust transfers from the friend to the developer.

Reality: Your friend may be a victim too, or may be getting a commission. Do your own verification regardless of who introduced you.

Chapter 6: What To Do If You've Been Scammed

If you discover you've been defrauded, act quickly. Time is critical for recovery and preventing the fraudster from victimizing others.

Immediate Actions (First 24-48 Hours)

1. Document Everything

- Gather all receipts, agreements, and communication records
- Take screenshots of websites and social media
- Write a detailed timeline of events
- Record names, phone numbers, and addresses of all contacts

2. Report to the Police

- File a report at the nearest police station
- Request a copy of the police report
- For large amounts, contact the Economic and Financial Crimes Commission (EFCC)
- Provide all documented evidence

3. Contact Your Bank

- If payment was recent, request a recall
- Provide police report to support the request
- Ask for the recipient's KYC information

4. Engage a Lawyer

- Hire a lawyer experienced in property fraud
- Discuss civil litigation options
- Consider a court injunction to freeze assets

Legal Recovery Options

Option	Best For	Timeline	Cost
Criminal Prosecution	Clear fraud, known perpetrator	2-5 years	Low (government prosecutes)
Civil Litigation	Recovering money, freezing assets	1-3 years	N500K-N2M
EFCC Investigation	Large-scale fraud, multiple victims	1-3 years	Free
Mediation	Willing developer, partial recovery	3-6 months	N100K-N500K

Support Resources

- **EFCC:** 09-4616380, efccnigeria.org
- **Police Special Fraud Unit:** Visit the SFU office in your state
- **Consumer Protection Council:** consumer.gov.ng
- **Real Estate Developers Association (REDAN):** Report fraudulent members

Don't Be Ashamed—Speak Out

Many victims stay silent out of embarrassment. This only helps the fraudsters. By reporting and sharing your story, you:

- Increase chances of recovery
- Prevent others from being victimized
- Help authorities track patterns
- Contribute to industry reform

Chapter 7: Building Your Defense System

Prevention is always better than recovery. This final chapter provides a comprehensive defense system to protect yourself and your family from real estate fraud.

Your Personal Due Diligence Protocol

Before Any Payment:

- ✓ Verify company registration at CAC
- ✓ Conduct land search at the registry
- ✓ Visit the land with an independent surveyor
- ✓ Verify all documents with issuing authorities
- ✓ Check developer's track record and references
- ✓ Have a lawyer review all agreements
- ✓ Confirm payment goes to verified company account
- ✓ Never pay more than 30% deposit
- ✓ Document every interaction

Building Your Professional Team

Every serious real estate investor needs a team of professionals:

Professional	Role	Cost Estimate
Property Lawyer	Contract review, legal verification	N50K-N200K per transaction

Registered Surveyor	Land verification, boundary confirmation	N50K-N150K per survey
Estate Agent (Licensed)	Market research, property sourcing	5-10% of property value
Property Valuer	Price verification, investment analysis	N30K-N100K per valuation

Family Protection Measures

- **Education:** Share this book with family members considering property investment
- **Verification Culture:** Make due diligence a family rule, not an option
- **Collective Decision-Making:** Major purchases should involve multiple family members
- **Cooling-Off Period:** Agree on a minimum 1-week decision period for all property purchases
- **Documentation:** Keep all property records in a secure, accessible location

Staying Informed

- Follow EFCC updates on real estate fraud cases
- Join real estate investment forums and communities
- Subscribe to industry publications and news
- Attend real estate seminars and workshops
- Network with other investors to share experiences

Final Word: Trust, But Verify

The Nigerian real estate market offers incredible opportunities for wealth building. But it also attracts those who would exploit your dreams. The difference between a successful investment and a devastating loss often comes down to one thing: verification.

Trust your instincts, but verify the facts. A legitimate developer will welcome your thoroughness. A fraudster will resist it. Let that be your guide.

At 12th City Real Estate Developers, we have built our reputation on transparency, integrity, and delivering on our promises. We encourage every potential buyer to verify our credentials, visit our

completed projects, and speak with our past clients. We have nothing to hide—and neither should any developer you consider working with.

Stay vigilant. Stay informed. Stay protected.

About the Author

Dr. Fadokun Oluwole is the Chief Operating Officer of 12th City Real Estate Developers LTD, one of Nigeria's fastest-growing real estate development companies. With over a decade of experience in the Nigerian real estate sector, Dr. Fadokun has developed expertise in operations management, risk assessment, and fraud prevention.

Throughout his career, Dr. Fadokun has been committed to raising standards in the Nigerian real estate industry. He has personally investigated numerous fraud cases, helped victims recover their investments, and developed the verification systems that protect 12th City's clients.

Dr. Fadokun holds advanced degrees in Business Administration and has completed specialized training in real estate risk management. He is a member of the Real Estate Developers Association of Nigeria (REDAN) and regularly speaks at industry conferences on the topics of fraud prevention and investor protection.

He is passionate about educating Nigerian investors and believes that knowledge is the most powerful weapon against fraud. This book is part of his mission to create a safer, more transparent real estate market for all Nigerians.

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